defeatism set in, and Sonia, like other members of the UPA, became a victim of it. As one core group member told me, ‘We lost our desire to fight.’

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By the time the summer of 2012 arrived, it was becoming obvious that the UPA-II government was a patient heading towards the intensive care unit with a lame-duck prime minister. Dr Singh always had two calling cards—his image as an honest politician and his track record as an economist. Now, both were coming under assault. In March that year, another CAG report, this time on coal block allocations, suggested a loss of Rs 1.86 lakh crore to the treasury. The opposition had fresh ammunition—but this time, it was directed at the prime minister personally.

Between 2006 and 2009, the prime minister was the coal minister. The CAG report claimed that as many as 134 coal blocks were given away in this period in an opaque manner without competitive bidding. Many of the beneficiaries had links to prominent politicians, especially of the ruling party. The government argued that the blocks were given out to enhance coal production at a time when the country was facing an energy crisis. The argument did not stick—a Supreme Court-supervised CBI probe was ordered. The Opposition had smelt blood. ‘I had gently warned the prime minister that handling the coal portfolio was a bad idea. I don’t think he realized what he was getting into,’ recalls a former aide.

There was more bad news for the prime minister. The economy appeared to be on an irreversible downturn. Growth had slowed down, manufacturing was struggling, jobs had plateaued, the rupee was weakening, fiscal deficit was out of control, inflation was on the rise. Worried about an activist judiciary, ministers and bureaucrats had stopped taking decisions. Business confidence in particular was at a low ebb—a retrospective tax in the 2012 Union budget had infuriated industry. Several big-ticket projects had been stalled because of environmental concerns. The Eurozone crisis had already taken a heavy toll. In the second week of June, the global ratings agency